

Creche Wise

Go-to-Market Wedge Strategy

How a new Irish entrant wins a beachhead against entrenched incumbents — by owning one niche first, then expanding.

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The strategy in one line. Win the **after-school / school-age childcare (SAC)** niche in Ireland first — where Creche Wise's **collection + direct-payments** edge is strongest and the incumbents' **learning-journal** advantage matters least — prove it with a handful of reference customers, then expand into full-day crèches.

1. Why a wedge, not “all-in-one for everyone”

Creche Wise is a 2026 entrant against vendors with 10+ years, reference bases and deep learning-journal products. Competing head-on on breadth means comparing our weakest area (journals, track record) to their strongest. A wedge flips that: pick the one segment where **our** strengths are the buying criteria and **their** strengths barely matter, win it decisively, earn references, then widen.

- **Lower trust barrier** — a focused tool for a specific pain is an easier first sale than “replace your whole system.”
- **Neutralises our gap** — SAC services need learning journals far less than early-years settings do.
- **Plays our unique cards** — the school-collection + authorised-collector workflow and direct payments.
- **Focuses a small team** — one message, one buyer, one onboarding playbook.

2. The chosen wedge

Primary wedge: After-school & school-age childcare (SAC) services — standalone after-school clubs and the after-school rooms inside full-day crèches.

Why this wedge wins

- **We own the hero workflow.** Collecting children from their primary school, an authorised-collector register with consent, and a daily collect/release log — a real safeguarding + operational need that incumbents barely touch (CrecheHQ has transport; none have the full collection + collector register).
- **The pain is acute and timed.** School-age **NCS reconciliation** is a known, recurring headache (a whole product, Enrolmy, exists just for it) — a sharp, demonstrable “days→hours” win.
- **Our weakness is irrelevant here.** SAC settings don't live in learning journals, so the incumbents' biggest advantage is neutralised.
- **Pricing fits.** A flat €74.99/mo beats per-child pricing exactly where SAC services sit (often 40–120 children).

Secondary, cross-cutting angle

“Get paid directly — flat price, SMS and payments included.” Each crèche collects fees into its **own** Stripe/Revolut account (merchant of record), with instalments, for one flat fee. This travels with the wedge and becomes the lead message when expanding to fee-heavy full-day crèches.

3. Ideal customer profile (beachhead)

Attribute	Definition
Segment	Irish after-school / school-age services, and full-day crèches running an after-school room
Size	~30–150 children (per-child tools get expensive at this scale; flat price wins)
Buyer	Owner / manager — usually the same person doing NCS returns and fee chasing; admin-overloaded
Trigger events	NCS reconciliation season; incumbent price rise/renewal; a collection/safeguarding scare; opening or growing an after-school room; Tusla inspection prep
Disqualify (for now)	Childminders (<10 children — cheaper per-child tools win); pure sessional early-years services whose #1 need is deep learning journals

4. Positioning & message

The “only” statement. Creche Wise is the **only** Irish childcare platform that runs the whole after-school day end-to-end — from **collecting children at their primary school** (with an authorised-collector register and daily release log) to **NCS-netted fees parents pay straight into your own account** — for **one flat monthly price with texting included**.

Four proof pillars to repeat everywhere

- **Collection & safeguarding** — know exactly who may collect each child, and log every handover.
- **NCS made fast** — reconcile against the Hive in hours, not days; inspection-ready.
- **Get paid directly** — money lands in your account, not ours; card, Revolut, SEPA, instalments.
- **One flat price, everything in** — SMS, payments and every feature; no per-child creep.

5. Beachhead → expansion path

Stage	Target	Lead message	Goal
Stage 1 — Beachhead	SAC services + after-school rooms	Collection + NCS + direct payments	Reference base, repeatable onboarding, revenue
Stage 2 — Adjacent	Full-day crèches that also run after-school	"You already trust us after school — run the whole setting"	Expand ACV, whole-setting footprint
Stage 3 — Broaden	General early-years crèche market	Full platform; journal depth now matured	Compete head-on with references in hand

Discipline: do not chase Stage 3 buyers (journal-led sessional services) until Stages 1–2 are proven. Saying "not yet the right fit" protects focus and win-rate.

6. Pricing & packaging for the wedge

- **Keep the flat price** (€74.99/mo or €809.89/yr) — it is the message. Show buyers the **total-cost math vs per-child** at their headcount (e.g. ~40+ children usually favours flat).
- **Founding-crèche offer** for the first ~10: a locked discounted rate (or extended free period) in exchange for feedback, a testimonial and a named case study.
- **Lower switching friction** — free guided migration/import, and a clear data-export promise so buyers never feel locked in.
- **No-card 30-day trial** stays the front door — far less friction than quote-gated incumbents.

7. Go-to-market motion & channels

Channel	How	Why it matters
Founder-led direct	Build a target list from the Tusla register / Pobal / CCC directories; personal outreach + live demo on the buyer's own NCS data	Highest conversion; where the first 10 come from
County Childcare Committees (CCCs)	All 30 CCCs run provider info sessions; offer free "NCS reconciliation" / "collection policy" workshops	Credibility + warm introductions at scale
Sector networks	Early Childhood Ireland & SAC-specific groups — presence, talks, helpful content	Awareness within a tight community
Referrals	Every happy crèche → incentivised referral (credit/discount)	Compounding, low-CAC growth
Content / SEO	Rank for "NCS reconciliation", "authorised collectors template", "after-school collection policy"	Capture high-intent search the incumbents own
Partners	Accountants/bookkeepers serving crèches; local Revolut/Stripe angle	Trusted third-party distribution

8. The first-10 plan (0→10 crèches, ~90 days)

Phase	Actions
Weeks 0–2	Lock wedge messaging; build a list of 50 target SAC services; polish the demo tenant; define the founding-crèche offer
Weeks 2–6	Outreach to the 50 → book ~10 demos → onboard 3–5 design partners (free/discounted) in exchange for feedback + testimonial + case study
Weeks 6–10	Get them live through a real NCS cycle; measure time-to-reconcile saved ; run a real collection day; capture quotes and numbers
Weeks 10–13	Publish 2–3 case studies; switch on referrals; begin CCC outreach; convert design partners to paid

90-day success gate: **5 crèches live, 2 published case studies, 1 referral, and a measurable NCS time-saving figure** you can quote in every pitch.

9. Building trust (the real blocker)

- **Named case studies with numbers** — “Crèche X cut NCS reconciliation from 2 days to 3 hours.”
- **Security & GDPR posture** — publish it; pursue **ISO 27001** (TeachKloud holds it) or, as an interim, a documented security overview + DPIA. Crèches hold sensitive child data and will ask.
- **Reference calls** — let prospects talk to a live crèche like theirs.
- **Free parallel-run / money-back assurance** for the first cohort to de-risk switching.

10. Competitive counter-positioning

Competitor	Their strength	We win when...	Walk away when...
Child Paths	Learning journals, long track record	Buyer cares about collection, direct payments, flat price, after-school ops	Their #1 need is deep journals / sessional early-years
Little Vista	Care+family apps, fees (EasyFees), brand	Flat all-in price & direct payout; whole after-school day	Buyer wants the established, journal-first brand
CrecheHQ	Irish, offline kiosk, transport, clear pricing	Collection + authorised collectors; Revolut; SMS included	Buyer needs heavy transport/fleet features today
Cheqdin	Broad, big review base, free tier	Irish-native NCS depth + collection; flat vs per-student	Very small setting happy on the free/low tier
Spreadsheets / Hive only	Free, familiar	Hours saved on NCS; fewer errors; get paid faster	Tiny setting with almost no admin

11. Objection handling

Objection	Response
"You're new — no track record."	Design-partner references + named case studies; founding-crèche guarantee; free parallel-run; a written data-export promise.
"We already use X."	Don't rip-and-replace — start with the after-school room or the payments piece; free migration; show the flat-price saving at their headcount.
"Is it NCS / Pobal / Tusla compliant?"	Yes — built around NCS/ECCE and the Early Years Hive. Offer a live reconciliation demo on their own data.
"What about learning journals?"	Be honest: we lead on operations, compliance and payments; here's our daily-records capability, and it's on the roadmap. For a journal-first service we may not be the fit yet.
"What's the price?"	One flat price — SMS and payments included, no per-child creep. Here's your total cost vs a per-child tool, and a 30-day no-card trial.

12. Milestones & metrics

Horizon	Target
90 days	5 live design partners; 2 case studies; a quotable NCS time-saving; referral engine seeded
6 months	15–25 paying crèches; one repeatable channel identified; published security/GDPR posture; early churn understood
12 months	50+ paying crèches; expansion into full-day underway; CAC & payback measured; ISO 27001 in progress

13. Key risks & mitigations

Risk	Mitigation
Trust / no references	Design partners → case studies → reference calls; founding-crèche guarantee
Learning-journal gap	Scope the wedge to de-emphasise it; ship "good enough" daily records; roadmap journals for Stage 3
Distribution / reach	CCC workshops + referrals + high-intent content; founder-led sales for the first 10
Support load (NCS)	Onboarding playbook, templates, self-serve help; price in the time; lean on the time-saved story
Founder bandwidth	Wedge discipline — one segment, one message; say no to Stage-3 buyers for now
Payment onboarding friction	Each crèche does Stripe/Revolut KYC — provide a guided setup checklist; make it part of onboarding

14. Product priorities that serve the wedge

- **Demonstrable NCS/Hive reconciliation speed** — the universal buy trigger; make the "days→hours" claim provable in a demo.
- **Polish the collection module** — it is the hero; make the collect/release register and authorised-collector flow flawless and printable.
- **"Good enough" daily records / observations** — enough not to lose on it in the wedge.
- **Security credentials** — GDPR posture now, ISO 27001 next.
- **Migration/import tooling** — make switching from a spreadsheet or incumbent painless.

Prepared by First Stack Solutions. Companion to the Irish Crèche Software Market Analysis (Oct 2026). Working draft for internal planning — revise as the first cohort teaches you what actually converts.